

STOCKINGS took another step ahead this season. Present in varied colours, patterns and patchworks, they were used extensively by **LECOANET-HEMANT** (right), **RINA DHAKA** and **KAVITA BHARTIA**.



ferred at the recent fashion weeks; arguments broke out between designers from the rival camps too. Cue's Rohit Gandhi even slapped designer Gaurav Gupta at an after-show party, accusing him of purposely delaying his 5 p.m. show at Emporio so that journalists couldn't make it to Pragati Maidan for the Cue show at 6 p.m.

Nair isn't sorry though. He justifies his move by saying that if he had changed the dates of DFW, his buyers might not have shown up. "That's why even next season, the DFW will coincide with the WIFW," he adds. Sunil Sethi, FDCI chief, scoffs. "There is a saying that the parasite hangs close to its host. If you believe in your designers and your fashion week, why won't buyers come? Why should the DFW be dependent on WIFW?" Sethi can afford to talk, having brought in Vittorio Radice, the boss of La La Rinascente, along with buyers from Anthropologie and Liberty to the WIFW.

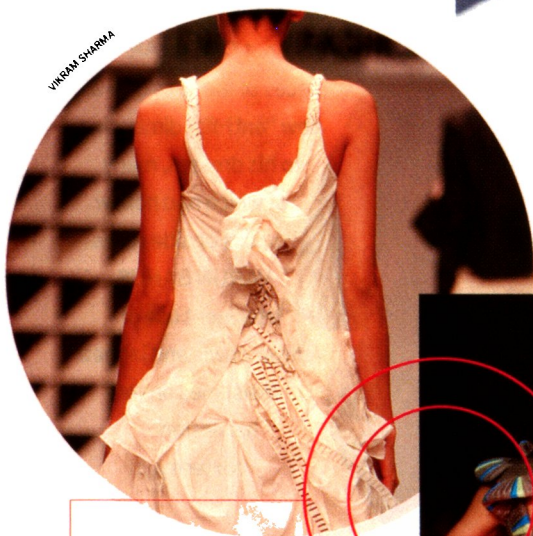
Much as usual, East was best when it came to sealing the deals. Tomoko Inzuka from Tokyo's Beams booked orders with Manish Arora, Payal Jain, Puja Arya, Kavita Bhartia and Namrata Joshipura. "They did not want to experiment

with new designers and preferred regulars. Beams reordered from my last collection and booked orders this season as well," says Joshipura. Ranna Gill's sales were her best till date, she claims, as she signed up with several small stores across the Middle East, while Joshipura has sent her lookbook to Vila Moda in Dubai. Indian stores like Evoluzione, Elahe, Maya and Samsaara also lapped up the new styles. "We have not deviated from our regular list of designers and have placed orders with Rajesh Pratap Singh, Raghavendra Rathore, Arora, Bal, Surily Goel, Varun Bahl among others," explains Shilpa Patel, buyer of Evoluzione.

Going by the number of buyers who showed up, the global recession seemed to have skipped the Indian fashion bazaar. Sethi says WIFW attracted 160 buyers this time, 20 per cent more than last season, while DFW claims to have got 165 buyers. The big picture will emerge only by the next fashion week in March 2009 though.

But already, the designers seem to be taking measures to counter a possible slump. Simple prêt lines, as opposed to overly conceptual pieces, is what ruled the spring summer runway. Tahiliani even waxed poetic in his press release for his summer harping on the need to "pull back, hold in the reins, push harder for a better tomorrow, with a focus on luxury with understatement... wake up to our own larger purpose over crass materialism."

For all the frenzy that the DFW and WIFW created, there



The **SEXY BACK** was brought to the forefront. **11.11 BY CELLDGDN** (above), **ROHIT BAL** (right), **ANJANA BHARGAV** and **CHAUHAN** used innovative detailing like ruffles, straps, cuts and knots on the backs of their dresses.



both take place at the same time and at venues located at two ends of the city? "That's how it is done in Paris," reasons Nair. "There are several things happening all at once during Paris Fashion Week and people are constantly shuttling between venues spread across the city," he reasons. Yes, but never parallel fashion weeks. Plus, this is Delhi where roads are a quagmire of a gazillion cars parked bumper to bumper at all times of the day. It wasn't just the audience that suf-